time west of Bellary. In 1946 the Tamil historian and numismatist T. G. Aravamuthan came across an eye-copy of a Brahmi inscription while going through the papers of Colin Mackenzie. Attached to it was a note explaining where the inscription had been found: 'Opposite the west Gopuram of Pedda Rama Devalayam in the southern part of a village called Rajula-Mandagiri in the Panchapalayam Taluk'.[7] Thanks to these directions the seventh Ashokan MRE was duly located, north-west of Bellary. Finally, in 1978 and 1979, two more MREs were found north of Bellary, making it nine in all.

These nine Ashokan MREs in the Bellary area of Karnataka make up half of the eighteen known MRE sites so far rediscovered. The eminent epigraphist Professor Harry Falk has determined that at least five of the nine are the work of the same scribe, who signs himself Capada, calls himself a *lipikara*, or 'engraver of words', and writes that word not in Brahmi lettering but in Kharosthi.[8] So he was a Gandharan from north-west India, or Gandhara-trained, which is just as one would expect, because this surely is where that Brahmi alphabet was first dreamed up.[9] What Ashoka also tells us in these Bellary MREs is that he is currently based at a provincial capital called Suvarnagiri, or 'golden hill', which to judge from the spread of these nine MRE locations must have been somewhere at or close to the modern town of Bellary and the imposing hilltop fort at its centre (see Map 6).

It seems that only after his conquest of Kalinga did Emperor Ashoka become fully aware of the consequences of his actions and begin to take his new faith seriously. In what must surely be one of the most remarkable confessions ever made by an all-powerful ruler, Ashoka tells us in his REs that in conquering Kalinga he caused a hundred thousand to be killed and a hundred and fifty thousand to be deported, with many others dying from other causes. He declares himself